running me out. With nothing going our way, we headed to The Oval for the fourth and final Test very low on morale. What was worse was that we had also lost our number-one ranking in the process, having lost three Test matches on the trot.

Stuck on ninety-nine

I had scored my ninety-eighth international hundred on 27 February 2011 while playing England in our second World Cup game in Bangalore, but there was no mention of the 100th hundred in the media at that stage. Less than two weeks later, I scored the ninety-ninth against South Africa at Nagpur, but still no one brought up the 100th. The topic did come up on television when I was in the eighties against Pakistan in the World Cup semi-final, but that was no more than a passing mention. It was only after the World Cup win that the media needed a new cause to obsess over and the 100th hundred fitted the bill: it had never been achieved before, it made for good television and newsprint and it was a landmark fans could be proud of. It was a recipe for unprecedented frenzy – without always appreciating the impact it might have on me.

I first became aware of all the fuss when I was on a family holiday in England in June 2011 before the Test series. I was asked if I had deliberately skipped the West Indies tour to ensure that the 100th hundred came at Lord's in the first Test. I did not have a Test hundred at Lord's (and now never will have) and this, I was informed, was my way of setting the record straight. Only, it was news to me. I would, of course, have been delighted to get the hundred at Lord's, but hundreds simply do not happen as easily as that.

The obsession soon turned into hysteria. Every time I went in to bat, I was supposed to get to the landmark hundred. Believe me, I wanted to get it out of the way. I was spending hours at the nets and felt good about my batting, but gradually the 100th ton was starting to play on my mind.

At The Oval in the fourth and final Test, which started on 18 August, England scored 591 in their first innings, with 235 from Ian Bell and another century from Pietersen. We were bowled out for 300 in reply and asked to follow on. I was dismissed for 23 in our first innings, trying to play a sweep shot to Graeme Swann, and was extremely angry at getting out that way. My mood wasn't helped by the fact that earlier I had been